

Episode 24: Once Upon a Time... (19) *Saint Seiya* Part 6 – Theatrical *Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods*, and Stories with Yamauchi-san

It's high school baseball season. The other day, while browsing West Tokyo tournament match results on the internet, huh? I saw my alma mater - Tokyo Metropolitan Fuji High School - in the match results. I hurriedly checked their record and amazingly they'd won through the 2nd and 3rd rounds to reach the best 16. Winning further - surprise! Best 8!

Actually, during my time at Tokyo Metropolitan Fuji High, they only had a soft baseball club due to the small schoolyard and other reasons. It became a hard baseball club in 2000.

The quarterfinals were last Friday at Jingu Stadium. Win and it's best 4, win further and it's **Koshien**. I twisted my various schedules (laughs) to watch Tokyo local **MX Television**'s broadcast from home in support.

It's a strange sensation. Cheering for my alma mater at this age. I'd never cheered for my alma mater during school or after graduation. Well, I certainly never thought my alma mater was that strong, but still thoughts of "maybe..." "possibly..." kept building excitement (laughs). Moreover, the opponent was **Kosei Gakuen**, Fuji High's neighbours. A **Marunouchi Line Honancho Branch** showdown! (Fuji High is at **Nakano-Fujimicho Station**, Kosei Gakuen at **Honancho Station**) Hmm, we can't lose this! (laughs)

The result: Unfortunately lost 2-7. But man, it was a really good game! I was moved by their never-giving-up attitude, scoring in the 8th and 9th innings. Really, they did well! Heartfelt applause for my alma mater's baseball club.

Well then.

Theatrical ***Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods***. Director: **Yamauchi Shigeyasu**, Script: **Koyama Takao**, Animation Director: **Araki Shingo**, Art Director: **Kubota Tadao**. Long-awaited participation in theatrical *Seiya*.

This was *Seiya*'s second theatrical work. As I wrote last time, I couldn't participate in the first one. Moreover, the long-awaited **Yamauchi**-directed *Seiya*. "I absolutely have to do this!" I went to directly petition the department manager with desperate resolve. Well, the manager apparently had already decided on me regardless of my petition (laughs).

Director **Yamauchi-san**. My encounter with Yamauchi-san was through a pilot film for some collaborative work. The title was ***Space Raiders***. Somewhere in space on a planet with incredibly strong winds, good guys and bad guys fight in fighter-like mechs... something like that. Several minutes long (?). Yamauchi-san was the director.

We decided to depict those raging winds - "constantly moving air currents" - through animation. We decided to animate "air currents" with cel drawings - about 2 types in the background depth, plus some in the foreground.

The screen, animated far beyond the storyboard sent from America, naturally made those "air currents" complex and intricate too. I thought single-colour "air currents" lacked depth, screen variation, and interest, so I consulted with Yamauchi-san to separate the multiple "air currents" in the drawings into different coloured separate cel specifications, then double them semi-transparently during photography.

Naturally, finishing became quite difficult work, but as intended, the screen turned out quite nicely. "Tsujita-kun, you do quite well." Getting those words gave me tremendous satisfaction.

Then that "Episode 26." Several subsequent TV *Seiya* episodes. Yamauchi-san and I tried creating various screens. Working with Yamauchi-san, who creates screens using solid layouts, animation, and photography techniques, always had unexpected elements -

stimulating and enjoyable work. Now a theatrical work. I was excited about trying even more things.

Incidentally, ***Space Raiders*** unfortunately remained just a pilot with no further development (bitter laugh).

So, theatrical ***Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods***.

The setting is **Asgard**, the Nordic gods' land. Learning of some strange events occurring, **Saori**, **Seiya**, **Shiryu**, and **Shun** head to Asgard. Asking about **Hyoga**'s safety - he'd gone ahead and lost contact - Asgard's leader **Dolbar** and **God Warrior Loki** deny knowledge. But Seiya and friends sense something plotting in their aggressive auras. That night, **Saori**, meeting **Dolbar** alone, falls into his evil hands and becomes captive. To save Saori, deadly battles between **Saints** and **God Warriors** begin... such a story.

The production schedule wasn't very good back then either, but this work was really well-made - it's in my personal all-time best ten. What didn't make it in time for colour during editing and dubbing was... just a few cuts of final collapse scenes as **dousa** (in-between animation photography). And I remember it being almost entirely domestic animation.

The animation was good, but above all the art backgrounds. Each cut approaches you with "this is theatrical version" feeling. Especially **Valhalla Palace** backgrounds were amazing. The majesty of the palace on sheer cliffs rising before heavy Nordic skies in the background depths. Holding backgrounds lined up on **saridashi** room shelves, I secretly grinned while sighing (laughs).

In the main story, I tried various things colour direction-wise. First, "shadows within shadows." Character acting where characters enter other characters' shadows (**Frey** and **Saori** in **Dolbar**'s shadow cuts) - usually expressed by doubling BL shadows over characters, but I wondered if shadow colours could create crisis or anxiety feelings?

Instead of BL shadow doubling, I had animation composite shadows and worked out those section colours, painting them in with colouring.

Also, this is direction territory not finishing, but in following scenes, as **Dolbar's** "technique," expressing drawing opponents into and absorbing them into different dimensions used photography to insert and replace multiple backgrounds. Making wave-pattern masks with animation, having 3-4 different colour scheme backgrounds drawn from the same source drawing, then inserting them during photography. Such techniques are **Yamauchi-san's** speciality. Ground gouging depictions also used 2 background types for insertion.

Next I tried "night colours." Until then in *Seiya*, night scenes were coloured with normal colour direction without particularly changing colours, but I created "night colours" just for the scene where **Seiya** and **Shiryu** run across vast night plains. Not simply making colours one step darker, but adding background spatial colours to dull them down.

Actually then, **Lifework**, who'd been helping with TV series, could help somewhat with finishing, so I asked them to handle "night colour" scenes together. Of course I created "night colour" specifications using **Taiyo Shikisai** paints. **Taiyo Shikisai** was really suited for this directional colour changing.

Additionally, a few cuts of **Seiya** running through **Valhalla Palace** before dawn also had twilight colour changes created and painted by **Lifework**, I think.

Well, looking back now, the "night colours" weren't very successful (bitter laugh), but this colour thinking approach would connect to later ***Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth***.

Besides these "night colours," each scene except image scenes was basically normal colour direction colouring. This was based on considering "character standing" - the policy of "let's keep fighting characters in battle scenes basically normal as before."

But unlike recent digital colouring, even normal cels in dark nights, just photographing cels + backgrounds with cameras onto film strangely created good atmosphere.

With mostly normal colouring, battle scenes and "technique" scenes dealing with light always had detailed high-contrast and image colouring cels made for photography fade-in/fade-out. Slowly when creating intervals, quickly and briefly when increasing tempo. This "light" acting is still basic to *Seiya* today.

March 1988. This theatrical *Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods* was released as one film in the spring "**Toei Manga Festival**." At that staff first screening wrap party, what was handed to me was the final script for *Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth*.

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